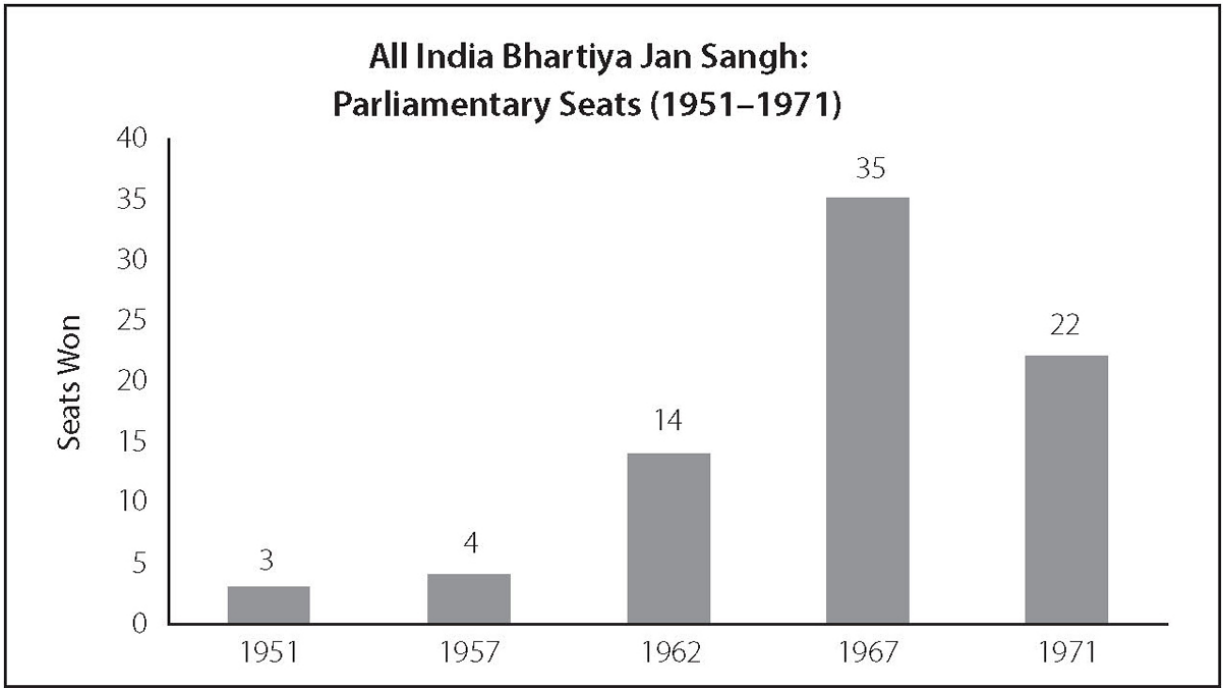


Source: ECI. Analysis by author

What was this Rule of 75? After a study of the Lok Sabha and assembly election results until then, Mehta argued that the Jan Sangh's problem was not that it did not win seats nor that its ideology was unwinnable. It was a question of electoral tactics, retention of gains and holding on to wins. 'At least in 75% of the seats won in previous election[s],' he argued, 'Jana Sangh fails to retain the same. In other words, the Jana Sangh cannot retain more than 25% of the seats won in the previous elections and loses the 75% of the seats won in the previous elections. This is precisely *The Rule of 75%*.'[103]

Mehta's critique needs some context. In absolute terms, the Sangh went from just three seats and 3.06 per cent vote share in the 1951 Lok Sabha elections to four seats (5.97 per cent) in 1957, fourteen (6.44 per cent) in 1962, thirty-five (9.31 per cent) in 1967 and twenty-two (7.35 per cent) in the 1971 general elections (see Figures 9.4 and 9.5). So, it was winning more seats in successive elections.